

Patient experience of referral delays

QRIP — Qualitative Research Intelligence Platform · generated 06 Sep 2026 19:13 UTC

Research question: How do patients experience and make sense of long waits between referral and first appointment?

Six semi-structured interviews with patients referred to a secondary care service in the last eighteen months.

Corpus and method

6 transcripts were segmented into 213 meaning units and coded into 219 codes, clustered into 19 themes. Mean coding confidence was 0.634. 60 contradictions were flagged.

Controls: similarity threshold 0.3, confidence threshold 0.6, minimum 4 supporting quotations, 2 participant minimum, sentence-level coding.

222 quotations are held in the project, 2 of them created by hand. The codebook holds 136 codes, 6 of which the researcher added.

Memos

Why 'the system does not do that' matters (analytic)

Updated body.

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Why 'the system does not do that' matters (analytic)

Updated body.

Themes

Re-merged theme (review)

Confidence 0.615 · coverage 26.5% · 6 participants · 58 quotations

Present in 6 of 6 participants across 58 coded segments. Affect is mostly unmarked; where it surfaces it is anger (10% of segments). Overall valence reads mixed or neutral. Participants are mostly describing here. Recurring language: 'system', 'appointment', 'hospital', 'nobody'. Internal cohesion 0.47 (mean pairwise similarity of member codes).

"Five weeks of knowing was easier than seven months of wondering would ever be." — P2

*"My wife worried more than I did, she is a worrier, and I told her, it will come when it comes."
— P4*

"There is not a great deal to tell, love." — P4

Alternative reading: Read through a gratitude lens rather than anger, this cluster becomes less an account of what the service did wrong and more an account of what participants had to carry. The same quotes support both readings; the choice is interpretive, not empirical.

Letter and work (confirmed)

Confidence 0.676 · coverage 7.3% · 6 participants · 16 quotations

Present in 6 of 6 participants across 16 coded segments. Affect is mostly unmarked; where it surfaces it is anger (6% of segments). Overall valence reads mixed or neutral. Participants are mostly describing here. Recurring language: 'sentence', 'letter', 'filing cabinet', 'date'. Internal cohesion 0.53 (mean pairwise similarity of member codes).

"I would rather everyone got the letter in three days than me getting it because of a favour." — P2

"It made me feel invisible, like the letter had just fallen down the back of a filing cabinet somewhere and I was the only person in the world who cared." — P1

"I went to the GP on the Tuesday about the numbness in my hand and I had a letter by the Friday with an appointment for the following month." — P2

Alternative reading: Read through a gratitude lens rather than anger, this cluster becomes less an account of what the service did wrong and more an account of what participants had to carry. The same quotes support both readings; the choice is interpretive, not empirical.

Referred and lovely (confirmed)

Confidence 0.76 · coverage 5.5% · 4 participants · 12 quotations

Present in 4 of 6 participants across 12 coded segments. Affect is mostly unmarked; where it surfaces it is gratitude (17% of segments). Overall valence reads mixed or neutral. Participants are mostly describing here. Recurring language: 'referred', 'ones', 'autumn', 'faster'. Internal cohesion 0.59 (mean pairwise similarity of member codes).

"My GP referred me in the January. She was lovely about it, she said it would be si" — P1

"My GP referred me in the January. She was lovely about it, she said it would be si" — P1

"My GP referred me in the January." — P1

Alternative reading: An alternative reading treats this as context rather than a theme in its own right: the material may be better placed as a condition shaping the other themes.

Phone Call and story (confirmed)

Confidence 0.636 · coverage 4.6% · 5 participants · 10 quotations

Present in 5 of 6 participants across 10 coded segments. Affect is mostly unmarked; where it

surfaces it is anger (10% of segments). Overall valence reads broadly negative. Participants are mostly describing here. Recurring language: 'phone call', 'good', 'neighbour's story', 'clearly drew'. Internal cohesion 0.49 (mean pairwise similarity of member codes).

"Very good. He explained the nerve thing clearly, drew me a diagram, gave me exercises, told me exactly what to do if it got worse and who to call." — P2

"If the whole thing had been like that I would be sitting here telling you a completely different story." — P5

"That one phone call is the difference between my story and my neighbour's story, and my neighbour waited fourteen months for something similar." — P2

Alternative reading: An alternative reading treats this as context rather than a theme in its own right: the material may be better placed as a condition shaping the other themes.

Nothing (confirmed)

Confidence 0.622 · coverage 3.6% · 5 participants · 8 quotations

Present in 5 of 6 participants across 8 coded segments. Affect is mostly unmarked; where it surfaces it is distrust (12% of segments). Overall valence reads mixed or neutral. Participants are mostly describing here. Recurring language: 'ringing', 'doubt', 'nothing', 'forgotten'. Internal cohesion 0.49 (mean pairwise similarity of member codes).

"I waited until March and then I started ringing." — P1

"Three times I gave them her date of birth, her medications, the same history, and every time it was as if we were starting from zero." — P5

"My father-in-law is waiting for a knee and he has heard nothing for seven months and he has started to assume he has been forgotten." — P2

Alternative reading: Read through a trust lens rather than distrust, this cluster becomes less an account of what the service did wrong and more an account of what participants had to carry. The same quotes support both readings; the choice is interpretive, not empirical.

Broken and sleeping (review)

Confidence 0.572 · coverage 3.6% · 5 participants · 8 quotations

Present in 5 of 6 participants across 8 coded segments. Affect is largely unmarked; the register is descriptive and mixed or neutral. Participants are mostly describing here. Recurring language: 'stopped', 'twelfth put', 'personally makes', 'sleeping'. Internal cohesion 0.55 (mean pairwise similarity of member codes).

"I told my wife, look, it is the twelfth, put it in the calendar, and then I stopped thinking about it." — P2

"It works when somebody personally makes it work." — P2

"And stop making families do the coordination, because families do it for free and then you never find out how broken the joins are." — P5

Alternative reading: An alternative reading treats this as context rather than a theme in its own right: the material may be better placed as a condition shaping the other themes.

Staff Blamed and excellent (confirmed)

Confidence 0.614 · coverage 2.7% · 5 participants · 6 quotations

Present in 5 of 6 participants across 6 coded segments. Affect is mostly unmarked; where it surfaces it is anger (17% of segments). Overall valence reads broadly positive. Participants are mostly describing here. Recurring language: 'consultant', 'every', 'reception', 'staff'.

Internal cohesion 0.48 (mean pairwise similarity of member codes).

"Only that I would not want the staff blamed for any of this." — P6

"The staff were excellent, every single one, from the woman on reception to the consultant." — P2

"The consultant was fine, he was thorough, he spent forty minutes with me and I have no complaint about him at all." — P1

Alternative reading: An alternative reading treats this as context rather than a theme in its own right: the material may be better placed as a condition shaping the other themes.

Honestly Luck (review)

Confidence 0.599 · coverage 2.3% · 5 participants · 5 quotations

Present in 5 of 6 participants across 5 coded segments. Affect is mostly unmarked; where it surfaces it is frustration (20% of segments). Overall valence reads broadly positive.

Participants are mostly describing here. Recurring language: 'chasing became', 'honestly luck', 'sound', 'luck'. Internal cohesion 0.52 (mean pairwise similarity of member codes).

"That was the beginning of the chasing, and honestly the chasing became a part-time job." — P1

"I should not have to sound like a threat to get an appointment." — P3

"Every person I spoke to sounded exhausted." — P5

Alternative reading: Read through a trust lens rather than frustration, this cluster becomes less an account of what the service did wrong and more an account of what participants had to carry. The same quotes support both readings; the choice is interpretive, not empirical.

Referral and urgent (confirmed)

Confidence 0.68 · coverage 2.3% · 2 participants · 5 quotations

Present in 2 of 6 participants across 5 coded segments. Affect is largely unmarked; the register is descriptive and mixed or neutral. Participants are mostly describing here. Recurring language: 'nineteen', 'somebody', 'second', 'urgent'. Internal cohesion 0.59 (mean pairwise similarity of member codes).

"Genuinely. If somebody had said, we have got your referral, you are number four hundred, it will be eighteen weeks, I would have got on with my life." — P1

"In August. Nineteen weeks after the second referral, so about eight months from the first one." — P1

"It was after the second time in A&E." — P3

Alternative reading: Concentrated in P1, P3. It may be an idiographic pattern rather than a shared theme — treat as a case-level finding until corroborated.

Conversation Completely and sitting (review)

Confidence 0.565 · coverage 2.3% · 4 participants · 5 quotations

Present in 4 of 6 participants across 5 coded segments. Affect is largely unmarked; the register is descriptive and mixed or neutral. Participants are mostly describing here. Recurring language: 'sits badly', 'sitting', 'completely', 'conversation completely'. Internal cohesion 0.56 (mean pairwise similarity of member codes).

"She rang the department herself while I was sitting there." — P2

"They are not sitting there withholding an appointment from me out of spite." — P4

"That is the bit that sits badly." — P1

Alternative reading: An alternative reading treats this as context rather than a theme in its

own right: the material may be better placed as a condition shaping the other themes.

Nearly Lost (confirmed)

Confidence 0.71 · coverage 1.8% · 3 participants · 4 quotations

Present in 3 of 6 participants across 4 coded segments. Dominant affect is confusion (25% of segments); overall valence reads broadly negative. Participants are mostly recounting here. Recurring language: 'stomach pain', 'earlier', 'year', 'nearly lost'. Internal cohesion 0.48 (mean pairwise similarity of member codes).

"I had been going back and forth for nearly a year by then with the stomach pain." — P1

"I was neither and I still nearly lost." — P6

"If it is a year, say a year." — P4

Alternative reading: An alternative reading treats this as context rather than a theme in its own right: the material may be better placed as a condition shaping the other themes.

This Account (review)

Confidence 0.542 · coverage 1.8% · 3 participants · 4 quotations

Present in 3 of 6 participants across 4 coded segments. Dominant affect is gratitude (25% of segments); overall valence reads broadly positive. Participants are mostly describing here. Recurring language: 'this account'. Internal cohesion 0.93 (mean pairwise similarity of member codes).

"That is more than some get." — P4

"They are just gone." — P5

"Two things at once." — P3

Alternative reading: An alternative reading treats this as context rather than a theme in its own right: the material may be better placed as a condition shaping the other themes.

Thanks and viewer (review)

Confidence 0.917 · coverage 1.4% · 1 participants · 3 quotations

Present in 1 of 6 participants across 3 coded segments. Dominant affect is gratitude (100% of segments); overall valence reads broadly positive. Participants are mostly describing here. Recurring language: 'thanks', 'leaves'. Internal cohesion 0.76 (mean pairwise similarity of member codes).

"viewer: Thanks for making the time. Can " — P1

"viewer: Thanks for making the time. Can " — P1

"I am the person who says thank you and leaves." — P1

Alternative reading: Concentrated in P1. It may be an idiographic pattern rather than a shared theme — treat as a case-level finding until corroborated.

Advocate and learned (review)

Confidence 0.672 · coverage 1.4% · 3 participants · 3 quotations

Present in 3 of 6 participants across 3 coded segments. Dominant affect is pride (33% of segments); overall valence reads mixed or neutral. Participants are mostly recounting here. Recurring language: 'learned', 'advocate', 'full-time teacher'. Internal cohesion 0.5 (mean pairwise similarity of member codes).

"But by then I had learned that if you are polite and you wait your turn you just wait forever."

— P1

“Yes. I am her daughter and I am her interpreter and I am her advocate and I am also a full-time teacher, so I was doing all of it in my lunch breaks.” — P5

“I feel stronger, because I learned how to advocate for myself and I did not know I could do that.” — P3

Alternative reading: An alternative reading treats this as context rather than a theme in its own right: the material may be better placed as a condition shaping the other themes.

Difficult and process (review)

Confidence 0.627 · coverage 1.4% · 3 participants · 3 quotations

Present in 3 of 6 participants across 3 coded segments. Dominant affect is gratitude (33% of segments); overall valence reads mixed or neutral. Participants are mostly describing here. Recurring language: 'process', 'difficult', 'hold'. Internal cohesion 0.59 (mean pairwise similarity of member codes).

“The care I received was outstanding and the process of getting to it was appalling, and I have found it difficult to hold both of those in my head at once.” — P6

“Take that person out and I do not think the process holds itself up.” — P2

“She was kind, she was not being difficult, she just read me what was on her screen.” — P3

Alternative reading: Read through a anger lens rather than gratitude, this cluster becomes less an account of what the service did wrong and more an account of what participants had to carry. The same quotes support both readings; the choice is interpretive, not empirical.

Word Lightly (review)

Confidence 0.66 · coverage 1.4% · 3 participants · 3 quotations

Present in 3 of 6 participants across 3 coded segments. Dominant affect is anger (33% of segments); overall valence reads broadly negative. Participants are mostly describing here. Recurring language: 'words urgent', 'word lightly', 'word'. Internal cohesion 0.74 (mean pairwise similarity of member codes).

“I held on to those two words, urgent and two weeks, and I counted the days.” — P3

“It was a disgrace, and I do not use that word lightly.” — P5

“That word did something to me.” — P6

Alternative reading: An alternative reading treats this as context rather than a theme in its own right: the material may be better placed as a condition shaping the other themes.

Appointments (review)

Confidence 0.683 · coverage 1.4% · 3 participants · 3 quotations

Present in 3 of 6 participants across 3 coded segments. Affect is largely unmarked; the register is descriptive and broadly negative. Participants are mostly describing here. Recurring language: 'mum kept', 'blood pressure', 'memory problems'. Internal cohesion 0.43 (mean pairwise similarity of member codes).

“I kept my appointments with the GP for the blood pressure.” — P4

“She was referred in the February for the memory problems.” — P5

“My mum kept saying no news is good news and I wanted to scream because no news was exactly the problem.” — P3

Alternative reading: An alternative reading treats this as context rather than a theme in its

own right: the material may be better placed as a condition shaping the other themes.

Named Contact and pals (review)

Confidence 0.68 · coverage 1.4% · 1 participants · 3 quotations

Present in 1 of 6 participants across 3 coded segments. Affect is largely unmarked; the register is descriptive and mixed or neutral. Participants are mostly describing here. Recurring language: 'practice manager', 'pals exists', 'named contact'. Internal cohesion 0.51 (mean pairwise similarity of member codes).

"I wrote to PALS, I copied in the practice manager, I asked for a named coordinator." — P5

"You have to know to ask for a named contact." — P5

"You have to know that PALS exists." — P5

Alternative reading: Concentrated in P5. It may be an idiographic pattern rather than a shared theme — treat as a case-level finding until corroborated.

Later and nurse (review)

Confidence 0.717 · coverage 1.4% · 2 participants · 3 quotations

Present in 2 of 6 participants across 3 coded segments. Dominant affect is gratitude (33% of segments); overall valence reads mixed or neutral. Participants are mostly recounting here. Recurring language: 'almost nobody', 'later', 'cardiac team'. Internal cohesion 0.53 (mean pairwise similarity of member codes).

"The cardiac team were brilliant, they explained everything, the nurse rang me two days later just to check I had understood." — P6

"Three weeks later I had a date that worked." — P6

"The nurse who did it was extraordinary, she spent two hours with mum, she spoke to her not to me, which almost nobody does." — P5

Alternative reading: Concentrated in P5, P6. It may be an idiographic pattern rather than a shared theme — treat as a case-level finding until corroborated.

Contradictions and tensions

Re-merged theme · severity 1.0

P1 frames this positively — "She was lovely about it, she said it would be six weeks, maybe eight." — while P4 reports the opposite: "There is not a great deal to tell, love."

Re-merged theme · severity 1.0

P1 frames this positively — "I remember walking out of that appointment feeling like something was finally going to happen." — while P4 reports the opposite: "I did not chase because there is no sense in chasing."

Re-merged theme · severity 1.0

P3 frames this positively — "And I think, honestly, because it made me sound like the kind of person who might complain properly." — while P1 reports the opposite: "You ring the GP and they say it is with the hospital now, we cannot see anything our end."

Re-merged theme · severity 1.0

P3 frames this positively — "And the appointment was good, I want to say that." — while P1 reports the opposite: "You ring the GP and they say it is with the hospital now, we cannot see

anything our end."

Re-merged theme · severity 1.0

P1 holds both positions within the same account: "Nobody could tell me where my referral actually was." against "So for three months it sat there rejected and nobody rang me." — an internal tension rather than a disagreement between cases.

Re-merged theme · severity 1.0

P3 frames this positively — "And I think, honestly, because it made me sound like the kind of person who might complain properly." — while P1 reports the opposite: "Nobody could tell me where my referral actually was."

Re-merged theme · severity 1.0

P3 frames this positively — "And the appointment was good, I want to say that." — while P1 reports the opposite: "Nobody could tell me where my referral actually was."

Re-merged theme · severity 1.0

P3 frames this positively — "And I think, honestly, because it made me sound like the kind of person who might complain properly." — while P1 reports the opposite: "You think, maybe I am making a fuss, maybe the pain is not that bad, maybe they triaged me and decided I am not urgent and they just did not bother..."

Re-merged theme · severity 1.0

P3 frames this positively — "And the appointment was good, I want to say that." — while P1 reports the opposite: "You think, maybe I am making a fuss, maybe the pain is not that bad, maybe they triaged me and decided I am not urgent and they just did not bother..."

Re-merged theme · severity 1.0

P3 frames this positively — "And I think, honestly, because it made me sound like the kind of person who might complain properly." — while P1 reports the opposite: "That is what got to me most, not being told."

Re-merged theme · severity 1.0

P3 frames this positively — "And the appointment was good, I want to say that." — while P1 reports the opposite: "That is what got to me most, not being told."

Re-merged theme · severity 1.0

P3 frames this positively — "And I think, honestly, because it made me sound like the kind of person who might complain properly." — while P1 reports the opposite: "In May a receptionist told me the referral had been rejected because a box on the form was not filled in."

Thematic analysis

Braun & Clarke (2006, 2019) reflexive thematic analysis

Phase 1 — Familiarisation: 6 transcripts segmented into 213 meaning units; speaker turns separated so interviewer prompts are held as context rather than coded.

Phase 2 — Generating initial codes: 219 codes generated across the corpus, each tied to a verbatim segment with an emotion and intent reading and a confidence score.

Phase 3 — Searching for themes: Codes grouped by semantic similarity at a cut of 0.3, yielding

19 candidate themes.

Phase 4 — Reviewing themes: 8 themes meet the support thresholds (4+ quotations, 2+ participants); the rest are held as candidates for review.

Phase 5 — Defining and naming: Each theme carries a definition, a defining quotation, an explicit alternative reading and a boundary note.

Phase 6 — Producing the report: Exportable as .docx narrative report, .xlsx codebook and .pdf summary, with the full audit trail attached.

Grounded theory

Strauss & Corbin paradigm model with constant comparison

Core category: Every Criticism and letter

The core category is 'Every Criticism and letter', present for 6 participants across 128 coded segments. It integrates 12 theme(s) and connects to 'Referred and lovely', 'Conversation Completely and sitting', 'Nearly Lost'. Participants respond to it primarily through the strategies they improvise — I waited until March and then I started ringing. — with consequences that are not yet well evidenced in this corpus.

Each new interview is still contributing fresh concepts. Sampling is not saturated; continue theoretical sampling.

Axial category: Every Criticism and letter

Causal conditions: I would rather everyone got the letter in three days than me getting it because of a favour. — P2

Phenomenon: It is the getting in that is broken, not what happens once you are through the door. — P4

Context: So the system does work, but only if you know the words. — P5

Action / interaction strategies: I waited until March and then I started ringing. — P1

Axial category: Referred and lovely

Causal conditions: Which is a terrible thing to have to advise, because the people who most need to be seen are the least able to be a nuisance. — P6

Axial category: Conversation Completely and sitting

Context: She rang the department herself while I was sitting there. — P2

Axial category: Nearly Lost

Phenomenon: If it is a year, say a year. — P4

Memo — emerging core: Every Criticism and letter

Written after coding 6 transcripts. Every Criticism and letter keeps re-appearing across cases with the properties System, Appointment, Hospital. What varies is not whether participants encounter it but how much work they must do to get around it. That variation is the dimension worth sampling on next.

Memo — sampling

Each new interview is still contributing fresh concepts. Sampling is not saturated; continue theoretical sampling. Theoretical sampling should now target the conditions under which the core

category does not hold.

Memo — negative cases

3 segments run against their theme. P1 in particular reports the opposite pattern: "That was the beginning of the chasing, and honestly the chasing became a part-time job." Any theory built here has to accommodate that, not explain it away.

Interpretative phenomenological analysis

Smith, Flowers & Larkin — idiographic, hermeneutic, double hermeneutic

GET: Every Criticism and nobody

Convergence 1.0 · present in P1, P2, P3, P4, P5, P6

"I remember walking out of that appointment feeling like something was finally going to happen."
— P1

"Five weeks of knowing was easier than seven months of wondering would ever be." — P2

GET: Letter and work

Convergence 1.0 · present in P1, P2, P3, P4, P5, P6

"It made me feel invisible, like the letter had just fallen down the back of a filing cabinet somewhere and I was the only person in the world who cared." — P1

"I would rather everyone got the letter in three days than me getting it because of a favour." —
P2

P2 and P3 occupy opposite ends of this theme (valence 0.23 vs -0.5); the theme holds the tension rather than resolving it.

GET: Phone Call and story

Convergence 0.833 · present in P1, P2, P3, P4, P5

"That is what the whole thing has taught me and I do not think that is a good lesson for a hospital to teach anyone." — P1

"Very good. He explained the nerve thing clearly, drew me a diagram, gave me exercises, told me exactly what to do if it got worse and who to call." — P2

P2 and P4 occupy opposite ends of this theme (valence 0.1 vs -1.0); the theme holds the tension rather than resolving it.

Absent from P6 — absence is data here, not missingness.

GET: Nothing

Convergence 0.833 · present in P1, P2, P3, P4, P5

"I waited until March and then I started ringing." — P1

"My father-in-law is waiting for a knee and he has heard nothing for seven months and he has started to assume he has been forgotten." — P2

Absent from P6 — absence is data here, not missingness.

GET: Broken and sleeping

Convergence 0.833 · present in P2, P3, P4, P5, P6

"I told my wife, look, it is the twelfth, put it in the calendar, and then I stopped thinking about it." — P2

"I was not sleeping." — P3

P5 and P4 occupy opposite ends of this theme (valence 0.14 vs -0.71); the theme holds the tension rather than resolving it.

Absent from P1 — absence is data here, not missingness.

Case: P1

P1's account is organised around 'Referral and nobody', 'Referred and lovely', 'Thanks and viewer'. The prevailing register is gratitude (mean valence 0.02), and experience is most often rendered in temporal terms. Read this case on its own before reading it against the others.

Case: P2

P2's account is organised around 'Blame', 'Letter', 'Department'. The prevailing register is trust (mean valence 0.13), and experience is most often rendered in relational terms. Read this case on its own before reading it against the others.

Case: P3

P3's account is organised around 'Sound and appointment', 'Urgent Flag', 'Cousin'. The prevailing register is anxiety (mean valence 0.05), and experience is most often rendered in temporal terms. Read this case on its own before reading it against the others.

Case: P4

P4's account is organised around 'Health Service', 'Autumn', 'Chief Executive'. The prevailing register is gratitude (mean valence 0.0), and experience is most often rendered in relational terms. Read this case on its own before reading it against the others.

Case: P5

P5's account is organised around 'Almost Nobody', 'Named Contact and pals', 'Coordination'. The prevailing register is anger (mean valence -0.01), and experience is most often rendered in temporal terms. Read this case on its own before reading it against the others.

Case: P6

P6's account is organised around 'Every Criticism', 'Letter and offshore', 'Nuisance'. The prevailing register is anger (mean valence -0.07), and experience is most often rendered in relational terms. Read this case on its own before reading it against the others.

Framework analysis

Ritchie & Spencer five-stage framework method

Stage 1 — Familiarisation: 6 transcripts read and segmented into 213 meaning units.

Stage 2 — Identifying a thematic framework: 7 a-priori dimensions retained and 6 emergent categories added from the data.

Stage 3 — Indexing: 163 segment-to-category assignments made; segments may index to more than one category.

Stage 4 — Charting: 6 x 13 matrix built; 62% of cells carry data.

Stage 5 — Mapping and interpretation: Patterns read down columns (across cases) and along rows (within case).

Every Criticism and nobody: Mixed and moderate; no single reading dominates the column.

Letter and work: Mixed and moderate; no single reading dominates the column.

Nothing: Mixed and moderate; no single reading dominates the column.

Broken and sleeping: Strongly divided: accounts run from -0.23 to 0.65 valence. Look for what distinguishes the cases at each end.

Referred and lovely: Strongly divided: accounts run from -1.0 to 0.23 valence. Look for what distinguishes the cases at each end.

Suggestions for change: Mixed and moderate; no single reading dominates the column.

Phone Call and story: Mixed and moderate; no single reading dominates the column.

Experience of the process: Mixed and moderate; no single reading dominates the column.

Narrative analysis

Labov & Waletzky structural model with plot-shape and positioning reading

4 of 6 accounts take a stable shape. Tellers consistently claim agency, even where outcomes were poor. The variation in plot shape is itself the finding: the same service produces different stories for different people.

P1 — redemptive arc

P1 tells a redemptive story. Falls and recovers: the trouble is narrated as something survived. The sharpest downturn comes at "I had been going back and forth for nearly a year by then with the stomach pain." The teller positions themselves as the actor: things are done, chosen, pushed for.

P2 — stable arc

P2 tells a stable story. Holds a level tone throughout; endurance rather than change. The sharpest downturn comes at "I went to the GP on the Tuesday about the numbness in my hand and I had a letter by the Friday with an..." Agency is not grammatically marked either way in this account.

P3 — stable arc

P3 tells a stable story. Holds a level tone throughout; endurance rather than change. The sharpest upturn comes at "She was kind, she was not being difficult, she just read me what was on her screen." The teller positions themselves as the actor: things are done, chosen, pushed for.

P4 — stable arc

P4 tells a stable story. Holds a level tone throughout; endurance rather than change. The sharpest downturn comes at "I did not chase because there is no sense in chasing." Agency is not grammatically marked either way in this account.

P5 — stable arc

P5 tells a stable story. Holds a level tone throughout; endurance rather than change. The sharpest downturn comes at "She was referred in the February for the memory problems." The teller positions themselves as the actor: things are done, chosen, pushed for.

P6 — contaminative arc

P6 tells a contaminative story. Rises then falls: an early good is spoiled by what comes after. The sharpest downturn comes at "It made it my fault." The teller is positioned as the one things

happen to; the grammar itself carries the powerlessness.

Content analysis

Manifest frequency counts with a latent (interpretive) layer

2762 words, 545 unique content terms, type-token ratio 0.5056.

Every Criticism and nobody: Manifest frequency puts every criticism and nobody at 35% of category hits across 6 participants. Latently, it carries anger and a mean valence of -0.0 — frequency alone would overstate how settled this is.

Communication: Manifest frequency puts communication at 10% of category hits across 6 participants. Latently, it carries anger and a mean valence of 0.05 — frequency alone would overstate how settled this is.

Letter and work: Manifest frequency puts letter and work at 9% of category hits across 6 participants. Latently, it carries anger and a mean valence of 0.06 — frequency alone would overstate how settled this is.

Access: Manifest frequency puts access at 9% of category hits across 5 participants. Latently, it carries trust and a mean valence of 0.03 — frequency alone would overstate how settled this is.

Staff: Manifest frequency puts staff at 8% of category hits across 6 participants. Latently, it carries anger and a mean valence of 0.09 — frequency alone would overstate how settled this is.

Referred and lovely: Manifest frequency puts referred and lovely at 8% of category hits across 6 participants. Latently, it carries sadness and a mean valence of -0.11 — frequency alone would overstate how settled this is.

Phone Call and story: Manifest frequency puts phone call and story at 5% of category hits across 5 participants. Latently, it carries anger and a mean valence of -0.09 — frequency alone would overstate how settled this is.

Systems: Manifest frequency puts systems at 5% of category hits across 5 participants. Latently, it carries anger and a mean valence of -0.03 — frequency alone would overstate how settled this is.

Every unit is coded by one deterministic pass, so this is not inter-coder reliability. Treat it as a map of where a second human coder should look: the 30 low-confidence and 18 multiply-interpretable units first.

Second-pass agreement

Re-merged theme — divergence: Only 29% overlap at the tighter cut: 41 code(s) split away and 0 unrelated code(s) joined. The boundary of this theme is unstable — check it by hand before reporting.

Letter and work — agreement

Referred and lovely — agreement

Phone Call and story — agreement: Reproduced with 70% overlap; 3 code(s) moved.

Nothing — agreement: Reproduced with 88% overlap; 1 code(s) moved.

Broken and sleeping — agreement: Reproduced with 62% overlap; 3 code(s) moved.

Staff Blamed and excellent — agreement: Reproduced with 83% overlap; 1 code(s) moved.

Honestly Luck — agreement: Reproduced with 60% overlap; 2 code(s) moved.

Referral and urgent — agreement

Conversation Completely and sitting — agreement: Reproduced with 80% overlap; 1 code(s) moved.

Nearly Lost — agreement: Reproduced with 75% overlap; 1 code(s) moved.

This Account — agreement

Thanks and viewer — agreement

Advocate and learned — agreement: Reproduced with 75% overlap; 0 code(s) moved.

Difficult and process — agreement

Word Lightly — agreement

Appointments — agreement: Reproduced with 67% overlap; 1 code(s) moved.

Named Contact and pals — agreement

Later and nurse — agreement

Reflexive note

Every theme in this report is one defensible reading of the corpus, not the only one.

Alternative interpretations, counter-cases and unstable theme boundaries are recorded above so that a reader can disagree with the analysis on the evidence rather than on trust.